CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

COMMERCIAL PILOT IN THE AI ERA

Autopilots fly the cruise. Airlines still put two licensed humans up front for everything that actually matters.

★ **TL;DR — Commercial aviation at a ~$160K median, on a 2–4 year road of flight training, ratings and the airline license ladder. The catch: you fund your own training years before the airline paycheck arrives.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

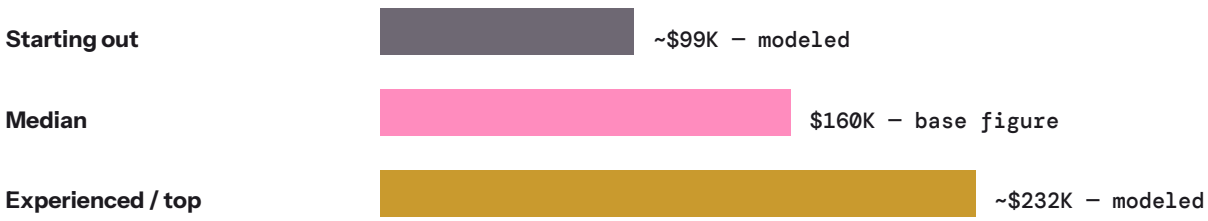
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$160K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Aviation is the most licensed profession on this site — and the license ladder is exactly what protects it.
- Automation flies the routine; command judgment in the non-routine is the career.
- The economics are back-loaded: expensive training, modest junior years, a median that rewards those who finish the ladder.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Commercial Pilot is a ~$160K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A COMMERCIAL PILOT ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Preflight planning, weather review and aircraft checks
- ✓ Flying the aircraft as part of a two-pilot crew
- ✓ Radio work, navigation and systems management
- ✓ Safety decisions in real weather, in real time

Think: the final human backup for a hundred people's worst day — trained until the backup looks boring.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Autopilot, flight-planning software, predictive maintenance and advanced simulators own the routine layers of aviation. Training itself is now heavily simulator-based — the machines teach, too.	Command: the legal and moral responsibility for the flight, and the judgment to delay, divert or refuse. Regulators license humans for that accountability, and passengers expect them.

⚠ **Training debt and medical fitness gate everything. Lose the medical certificate and the career ends — check your fitness for it before spending on flight hours.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The best office view in any profession ✓ A structured ladder where every rung is defined ✓ Travel isn't a perk; it's the job description	✗ Schedules run on seniority — juniors get what's left ✗ Years of training costs before the strong pay ✗ Time away from home as a permanent condition

Good fit? Disciplined, calm under procedure, medically fit — and able to fund a long training ladder.
Bad fit? You need income quickly, or your medical fitness for flying is in doubt.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — UNIVERSITY AVIATION PROGRAM	DOOR B — INDEPENDENT FLIGHT SCHOOLS
A degree program with flight training built in and airline pathway partnerships. Structured, financed like education, and designed to walk you up every rung of the ladder in order.	Train certificate by certificate at local flight schools, often while working another job. Slower and self-managed, but flexible — and the licenses earned are exactly the same.

Smart move: Get the top-level aviation medical check done before you spend serious money on training. It's the cheapest career insurance in the entire profession.
Where you land after: Airline first officer, then the captain track — or corporate and charter aviation on a different lifestyle setting.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MEDICAL FIRST	FIRST CERTIFICATE	INSTRUMENT AND	BUILD FLIGHT	THE AIRLINE-LEV	FIRST OFFICER

STEP 1 — Medical first

FIRST · BEFORE TRAINING

- Complete the aviation medical examination for the level you ultimately need
- Only invest in training once your fitness to fly is confirmed

STEP 2 — First certificate

YEAR 1

- Ground school and flight training toward your first pilot certificate
- Take a discovery flight and choose your school route

STEP 3 — Instrument and commercial ratings

YEARS 1-2

- Add the instrument rating: flying on instruments, in weather
- Earn the commercial certificate that lets you be paid to fly

STEP 4 — Build flight hours

YEARS 2-3

- Accumulate the experience airlines require — instructing is the classic paid route
- Every hour logged is a rung: keep records impeccable

STEP 5 — The airline-level license

LICENSE · YEARS 3-4

- Complete the highest license tier the airlines require, with its exams and checks
- Prepare for airline-style interviews and simulator evaluations

STEP 6 — First officer seat

THE DESTINATION

- Enter airline or corporate training and learn your aircraft type
- Begin the seniority clock — in aviation, starting it is everything

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: research the aviation medical requirements and book the examination.

□ Days 1–30: discovery flight taken; flight schools compared and one chosen.

□ Days 31–60: ground school underway; first lessons logged.

□ Days 61–90: training rhythm established; the full license ladder mapped with dates.

□ Day 90: you're a trainee pilot with a medical, a school and a ladder — the airline seat is years away and genuinely on the path.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE LADDER IS THE CAREER. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.